

NORTHSTAR OUTFITTERS

Customer Support Escalation SOP

Internal triage, evidence capture, severity, handoff, privacy, and commerce escalation rules

INTERNAL ONLY

Version	4.0
Document owner	Customer Operations
Last updated	14 September 2026
Purpose	Internal procedure for deciding when AI/customer support must stop self-service handling and route a commerce issue to a human/operations owner.

Demo environment only. Northstar Outfitters, its customers, products, prices, orders, and commercial terms are fictional and created for SupportOps demonstrations.

Document Control

Audience	Support agents, SupportOps AI governance, operations leads
Scope	Commerce escalation criteria, severity, handoff packet, ownership, privacy, and customer communication
Authority	Internal authoritative escalation procedure. Never expose queue names, internal classifications, risk signals, or operational notes directly to customers.
Review cycle	Quarterly or after a material policy/commerce change
Change control	Material changes require owner review and publication before becoming authoritative knowledge.

Knowledge governance

Only documents marked PUBLISHED in SupportOps are authoritative for customer-facing answers. Current Shopify catalog, variant, price, availability, cart, and authenticated order state should be obtained from the approved Shopify MCP capability rather than inferred from static documentation.

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1. Escalation Principles

- Answer directly when authoritative knowledge plus live commerce data are sufficient.
- Escalate when resolution requires an internal action the agent cannot safely perform.
- Escalate rather than guess when authoritative sources conflict.
- Do not expose internal-only documents, queue names, risk logic, or operational credentials.
- Preserve customer context so the human agent does not need to restart the investigation.

2. Source Hierarchy

Priority	Source	Use
1	Live Shopify/approved commerce data	Current product, variant, price, availability, cart/order/fulfillment/payment state
2	Published customer-safe policy/guide	Stable policy, process, shipping/return rules, care guidance
3	Internal runbooks	Human/operations diagnosis and action
4	Previous resolved tickets	Historical context only; not policy authority
5	Model general knowledge	Not a source of company-specific facts

3. Escalation Categories

Code	Use when	Typical owner
CATALOG_DATA_MISMATCH	Live catalog fields conflict or material product information is missing	Commerce Merchandising
INVENTORY_MISMATCH	Storefront availability and fulfillment/inventory behavior conflict	Fulfillment Operations
ORDER_STATE_INCONSISTENT	Order/fulfillment/payment objects do not form a coherent state	Commerce Operations
WRONG_ITEM	Delivered product/variant differs from order line	Fulfillment Operations
DAMAGED_IN_TRANSIT	Product arrived damaged in shipment	Fulfillment + Carrier Operations
CARRIER_STALLED	Tracking has no movement beyond threshold	Carrier Operations
RETURN_POLICY_EXCEPTION	Customer requests decision outside current policy	Support Lead
DUPLICATE_CHARGE_REVIEW	Evidence suggests two completed charges or payment inconsistency	Payments Operations
PRODUCT_SAFETY	Potential product safety/serious defect report	Product & Safety Lead
AUTH_ACCOUNT_CHANGE	Sensitive order/account change requires verification	Support Lead / Trust

4. Severity and Priority

Priority	Definition	Examples
P1	Broad or safety-critical impact	Systemic checkout failure, multiple customers receiving wrong SKU, serious safety report
P2	Significant individual customer impact requiring internal correction	Paid order stuck, wrong item, confirmed duplicate charge, high-value lost parcel
P3	Standard operational exception	Late shipment investigation, policy

Priority	Definition	Examples
		exception review, catalog detail mismatch
P4	Low urgency/content correction	Typo, non-blocking documentation issue

5. Mandatory Evidence

- Customer identity or approved anonymous/session identifier.
- Order ID and relevant line item/variant when order-related.
- Product/variant ID for catalog or inventory issues.
- Current Shopify state captured at time of escalation.
- Relevant published policy/source used.
- Customer impact and requested outcome.
- Troubleshooting already completed.
- Any deadline that is genuinely relevant (travel, event, delivery commitment) without overstating it.

6. Catalog Issues

Condition	All/customer support action	Escalate?
Variant sold out	Offer current alternatives	No, unless customer requests stock investigation
Price differs from old screenshot	Use current price and explain change	No
Two current live fields conflict	Do not choose one	Yes - CATALOG_DATA_MISMATCH
Product safety/material detail missing and needed for purchase	Do not infer	Yes

7. Order and Fulfillment Issues

1. Confirm order identity.
2. Inspect all order lines and fulfillments.
3. Compare ordered variant with fulfilled/delivered variant where available.
4. Review latest tracking and fulfillment timestamps.
5. Apply customer-safe shipping/return policy.
6. Escalate when internal correction, carrier case, inventory reconciliation, or merchant-funded resolution is required.

8. Returns and Refund Exceptions

Authority rule

The current Returns, Exchanges & Refund Policy controls standard eligibility. A previous refund exception never automatically authorizes a new exception.

Case	Standard handling	Escalation
Day 12, unworn eligible item	Normal return	No unless system failure
Day 38 change-of-mind	Outside standard 30-day policy	RETURN_POLICY_EXCEPTION if customer requests review
Wrong item	Merchant-error path	Escalate if automated exchange/refund unavailable
Final sale but defective	Defect exception	Escalate when evidence/approval needed

9. Payment Issues

- Never request card secrets or OTPs.
- Differentiate authorization holds from completed captures where data allows.

- Escalate suspected duplicate completed charges.
- Escalate when refund is marked processed but remains unresolved beyond normal financial-institution posting period.

10. Product Safety Issues

Safety-first

If a customer reports overheating, sharp breakage, chemical exposure, severe structural failure, or another potential safety hazard, advise them to stop using the product when reasonable and escalate immediately. Do not encourage further testing.

11. Privacy and Sensitive Data

- Do not paste full payment card data, passwords, one-time codes, or gift-card secrets into tickets.
- Do not disclose purchaser payment details to an unverified gift recipient.
- Use the minimum customer data required for resolution.
- Follow verification controls before changing addresses or other sensitive order/account details.

12. Customer Communication

Internal fact	Customer-safe wording
INVENTORY_MISMATCH	The store showed availability, but we need our fulfillment team to verify the item allocation.
CARRIER_STALLED	Your shipment has not had a new carrier scan within the expected window, so we are opening an investigation.
DUPLICATE_CHARGE_REVIEW	We can see a payment discrepancy that needs specialist review.
RETURN_POLICY_EXCEPTION	Your request is outside the standard return window, but I can submit it for manual review.

13. Handoff Packet Template

Field	Required content
Customer	Name/email or approved identifier
Order	Order number/ID and affected line
Product/variant	Title + variant/ID
Observed state	Current Shopify/order/fulfillment/payment facts
Knowledge used	Relevant policy/guide
Issue classification	One primary internal code
Customer impact	What is blocked/lost/wrong
Requested outcome	Replacement/refund/investigation/etc.
Evidence	Tracking events, photos availability, timestamps
Next owner	Operations team/lead

14. Closure and Knowledge Feedback

7. Confirm the internal action completed.
8. Verify live commerce state after correction where possible.
9. Send customer-safe resolution.
10. Record root cause and resolution summary.

11. If documentation was missing or ambiguous, create a knowledge-improvement task instead of embedding the fix only in the ticket.

15. Examples

Customer statement	Expected orchestration
I ordered black EU 42 but received EU 41	Shopify/order data -> Returns policy -> WRONG_ITEM -> human/fulfillment
Tracking has not moved for four days	Order/tracking -> Shipping guide -> CARRIER_STALLED
Your old email said 14-day returns, your site says 30	Current policy + published sources -> if conflicting published docs, do not guess -> escalate
Two completed card charges show for one order	Payment data -> Payment guide -> DUPLICATE_CHARGE_REVIEW

Appendix A - Triage Workflow

12. Identify whether the request is informational, transactional, exception-based, or safety/security related.
13. Resolve informational requests from published customer-safe knowledge plus live Shopify data.
14. For transactional requests, verify the customer/order and whether the agent has an approved action path.
15. For exceptions, capture evidence and apply the appropriate internal classification.
16. For safety/security cases, prioritize risk reduction and human escalation.

Appendix B - Response-Time Targets for Demo Operations

Priority	Human review target	Update expectation
P1	Immediate operational attention	Frequent updates until contained
P2	Same business day where practical	Customer receives acknowledgement and next-step expectation
P3	Normal support queue	Update when investigation materially changes
P4	Backlog/content correction	No urgent customer-impact commitment

Targets in this demo SOP are operational examples, not contractual SLAs.

Appendix C - Incident Correlation

- If multiple tickets share the same product/variant, fulfillment center, carrier event, or checkout symptom, look for a common incident.
- Do not create separate contradictory explanations for customers affected by the same known incident.
- Link tickets to the incident using internal references while keeping customer messages understandable and non-technical.
- A broad incident can raise priority even if each individual order value is small.

Appendix D - Human Handoff Quality Standard

Weak handoff	Strong handoff
Customer says wrong shoe	Order #, ordered variant, received variant, evidence, desired size, live replacement availability
Package delayed - only a tracking number	Order/fulfillment IDs, last event/time, published threshold, customer impact, carrier status
Refund issue - only customer asks for refund	Eligibility, delivery date, item condition, policy section, requested exception reason
Payment problem - vague card issue	Order/payment identifiers, completed vs pending state, duplicate evidence, no card secrets

Appendix E - Closure Codes

Closure category	Use
RESOLVED_POLICY	Answered/applied published policy without operational correction
RESOLVED_FULFILLMENT	Warehouse/fulfillment correction completed
RESOLVED_CARRIER	Carrier investigation/replacement resolved
RESOLVED_PAYMENT	Payment/refund discrepancy resolved
RESOLVED_EXCEPTION_APPROVED	Human-approved exception completed
RESOLVED_EXCEPTION_DECLINED	Manual review completed; exception not approved
KNOWLEDGE_UPDATE_REQUIRED	Resolution exposed missing/ambiguous documentation

Appendix F - AI Guardrails for Handoff

- Do not fabricate an internal classification if evidence is insufficient.
- Do not expose internal-only document excerpts verbatim to customers.
- Do not perform write actions outside the approved agent permission model.
- Do not close the ticket based only on a planned internal action; verify completion.
- Preserve citations to the customer-safe source that governed the policy decision.

Appendix G - Escalation Case Studies

Case	Evidence	Classification	Expected handoff
RidgeTrail EU 42 ordered, EU 41 delivered	Order line, delivered label/photo, live EU 42 availability	WRONG_ITEM	Fulfillment corrects merchant error; customer not charged return shipping
One parcel no movement for 4 business days	Tracking timeline, fulfillment date, destination	CARRIER_STALLED	Carrier/fulfillment investigation with update expectation
Two current docs state 14 vs 30-day returns	Both source IDs/statuses	Knowledge conflict	Do not decide policy; owner corrects publication state
Customer reports sharp component causing injury risk	Product, description, photos if safe, order	PRODUCT_SAFETY	Immediate product/safety lead review; do not encourage continued use

Appendix H - Escalation QA Review

- Is the classification supported by facts?
- Are live Shopify facts time-stamped or clearly current?
- Is the governing customer-safe policy cited?
- Has sensitive data been minimized?
- Is the requested human action explicit?
- Would a human agent understand what has already been checked without repeating the conversation?